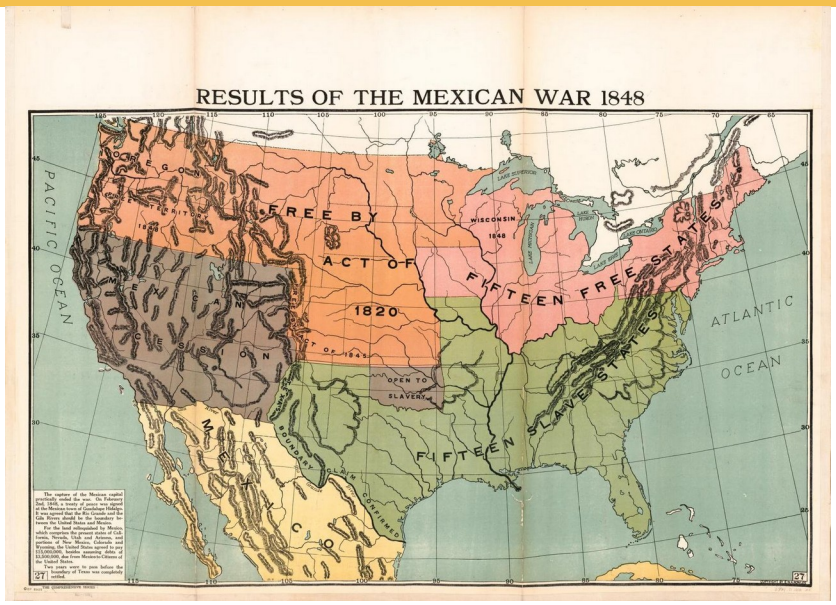
PROMISE & PRACTICE · GROWTH & CONFLICT · SOURCE ANALYSIS

La Invasión

One war, seen from the south

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about La Invasión, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.



"Results of the Mexican War, 1848" — the dark band marks the Mexican Cession: roughly half of Mexico's national territory, lost to the United States. Map, public domain (Library of Congress).

THE SOURCES

THE SAME SPARK, TWO NAMES

> *The United States: Mexico "has invaded our territory and shed American blood upon the American soil." Mexico: a foreign army crossed the Río Bravo onto Mexican land, and Mexico's soldiers defended their own country against la invasión*

How each nation described the war's start.

THE SAME BATTLE, TWO PICTURES

> *In American prints, Mexican soldiers are shown fleeing and American officers ride in triumph. In Mexican memory, the cadets of Chapultepec — the Niños Héroes — die rather than surrender the flag. The winners painted the victories; the losers canonized the sacrifice*

Buena Vista and Chapultepec in each memory.

THE SAME TREATY, TWO MEANINGS

> *To the United States: a bargain — the Mexican Cession and a path to the Pacific for $15 million. To Mexico: the loss of half the national territory at gunpoint, with the payment felt as an insult rather than a purchase*

Guadalupe Hidalgo, 1848.

A VERDICT FROM INSIDE THE WINNING ARMY

> *"I do not think there was ever a more wicked war than that waged by the United States on Mexico… only I had not moral courage enough to resign."*

Ulysses S. Grant, who fought in the war, 1885.

YOUR WORK

A. ALMOST EVERY PICTURE OF THIS WAR — INCLUDING THE ONES IN THIS PRESENTATION — WAS MADE BY AMERICAN PRINTMAKERS. HOW MIGHT THAT SHAPE WHAT WE CAN 'SEE' OF THE WAR, AND WHOSE EXPERIENCE IS MISSING?

a. Almost every picture of this war — including the ones in this presentation — was made by American printmakers. How might that shape what we can 'see' of the war, and whose experience is missing?

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B. MEXICO KEPT MUCH OF ITS MEMORY OF THE WAR IN MONUMENTS AND SONGS RATHER THAN IN BATTLE PRINTS. WHY MIGHT A DEFEATED NATION PRESERVE ITS PAST THAT WAY?

b. Mexico kept much of its memory of the war in monuments and songs rather than in battle prints. Why might a defeated nation preserve its past that way?

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A. TAKE ONE EVENT — THE SKIRMISH ON THE RIO GRANDE, THE FALL OF CHAPULTEPEC, OR THE TREATY OF GUADALUPE HIDALGO. WRITE THE AMERICAN SENTENCE FOR IT, THEN THE MEXICAN SENTENCE FOR IT. WHAT CHANGED — THE FACTS, OR THE FRAMING?

a. Take ONE event — the skirmish on the Rio Grande, the fall of Chapultepec, or the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo. Write the American sentence for it, then the Mexican sentence for it. What changed — the facts, or the framing?

_____

B. WHY CAN THE U.S. CALL THIS A “DEFENSIVE” WAR WHILE MEXICO CALLS IT “LA INVASIÓN,” AND BOTH POINT TO THE SAME EVENTS ON THE RIO GRANDE?

b. Why can the U.S. call this a “defensive” war while Mexico calls it “la invasión,” and both point to the same events on the Rio Grande?

NAME ONE HARD FACT ABOUT THE WAR THAT BOTH THE AMERICAN AND THE MEXICAN TELLINGS WOULD HAVE TO ACCEPT — THEN ONE THING THEY FLATLY DISAGREE ABOUT. WHAT MAKES THE FIRST KIND OF CLAIM DIFFERENT FROM THE SECOND?

Name one hard fact about the war that BOTH the American and the Mexican tellings would have to accept — then one thing they flatly disagree about. What makes the first kind of claim different from the second?

CLAIM — HAVING NOW READ BOTH SIDES: WAS THE MEXICAN-AMERICAN WAR THE FULFILLMENT OF A NATIONAL DESTINY, OR AN INVASION OF A WEAKER NEIGHBOR? TAKE A CLEAR POSITION.

CLAIM — Having now read both sides: was the Mexican-American War the fulfillment of a national destiny, or an invasion of a weaker neighbor? Take a clear position.

EVIDENCE — GIVE AT LEAST ONE SPECIFIC FROM THE AMERICAN TELLING AND ONE FROM THE MEXICAN TELLING TO SUPPORT YOUR CLAIM.

EVIDENCE — give at least one specific from the American telling and one from the Mexican telling to support your claim.

REASONING — YOU READ THE SAME WAR TWICE AND REACHED ONE VERDICT. WHAT DOES THAT PROVE ABOUT THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN WHAT HAPPENED AND HOW A NATION CHOOSES TO REMEMBER IT?

REASONING — you read the same war twice and reached one verdict. What does that prove about the difference between what happened and how a nation chooses to remember it?

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — La Invasión

a. Almost every picture of this war — including the ones in this presentation — was made by American printmakers. How might that shape what we can 'see' of the war, and whose experience is missing?: Open response.

b. Mexico kept much of its memory of the war in monuments and songs rather than in battle prints. Why might a defeated nation preserve its past that way?: Open response.

a. Take ONE event — the skirmish on the Rio Grande, the fall of Chapultepec, or the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo. Write the American sentence for it, then the Mexican sentence for it. What changed — the facts, or the framing?: Open response.

b. Why can the U.S. call this a "defensive" war while Mexico calls it "la invasión," and both point to the same events on the Rio Grande?: Open response.

Name one hard fact about the war that BOTH the American and the Mexican tellings would have to accept — then one thing they flatly disagree about. What makes the first kind of claim different from the second?: Open response.

CLAIM — Having now read both sides: was the Mexican-American War the fulfillment of a national destiny, or an invasion of a weaker neighbor? Take a clear position.: Open response.

> *Look for a response along the lines of: "Having read both sides, I think the war is best understood as… because…"*

EVIDENCE — give at least one specific from the American telling and one from the Mexican telling to support your claim.: Open response.

REASONING — you read the same war twice and reached one verdict. What does that prove about the difference between what happened and how a nation chooses to remember it?: Open response.